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# Carrie Wagner (B): Case Discussion Answers

## 1. How Carrie establishes authority as Sales Director and deals with the "heir apparent"

**Overall: a strong, well-judged approach.**

- **Setting the tone early.** When a manager said she'd have to "learn to be less rigid," she replied that he, not she, would have to adapt. This showed confidence and refused to be tested into submission. She then stated two non-negotiables: teamwork and professional ethics. That told the team how she would lead without sounding like a threat.
- **Handling the heir apparent privately.** She met him one-on-one after the group meeting instead of confronting him publicly. She acknowledged that she needed his field experience, which she lacked, and offered a trade: visibility in the department now, and her support for a promotion elsewhere later.
- **Following through.** A year later she kept her promise. This built trust and turned a potential rival into an ally.

**Critique:** Her first reply was a little confrontational, and it risked alienating the team. Her self-assurance and credibility on delivery balanced this. She also never tried to prove herself in sales expertise. She used his, which is a mark of a secure leader.

## 2. The MBA and "putting a name on things"

**A smart decision, with caveats.**

- **Why it was valuable.** After 18 years of working on instinct, the MBA gave her a framework and vocabulary for what she already did well. This boosted her self-confidence. The timing was ideal, since she was moving into an executive role where strategic thinking matters more than technical skill.
- **Credibility and competition.** Executive director positions are fiercely competitive, and an MBA is a signal of readiness for senior roles. It also gave her a peer network at a time when colleagues were not forthcoming with help.
- **Combining theory and practice.** She could apply concepts immediately at work, which makes learning more effective.
- **Risks.** Doing a part-time MBA while stepping up to a major role is a heavy workload. Formal credentials can also create a "paper over experience" trap if used as a crutch. In her case this wasn't an issue, since her experience was already strong.

## 3. Performance as Director of Customer Service (consumer market)

**Very good, arguably excellent.**

**Strengths:**

- **Diagnosed before acting.** She held listening meetings of about 30 people each to understand the issues.

- **Included middle managers.** She invited front-line and middle managers so they would not feel bypassed.
- **Built credibility through follow-through.** Previous executives hadn't followed up. She set a fixed three-month meeting cycle, assigned issues to managers, and sent updates and memos. Small wins accumulated into commitment.
- **Visible and approachable.** Breakfast meetings and a central office location made her accessible.
- **Self-aware delegation.** Knowing she wasn't a "detail person," she assigned someone to summarize the ideas.
- **Personnel changes.** She brought in complementary expertise.

**Weaknesses:**

- She initially felt overwhelmed and struggled to prioritize.
- Most managers skipped her meetings at first, showing resistance she needed to work through.

**Result:** Morale and credibility improved, and her team was sought out as a partner for large-customer strategy, a clear turnaround.

## 4. Why Carrie was reluctant to lead the logistics initiative, and was she right to accept?

**Reasons for reluctance:**

- **Lack of expertise.** She knew nothing about the business market, which involves large packages and tight cost control.
- **Comfort zone.** Everything in the consumer division was running smoothly, and her team had earned credibility.
- **Emotional attachment** to the managers she had chosen and trained.
- **Rebuilding from scratch.** It meant a new team with undefined skill requirements.
- **High risk and visibility.** Time-critical logistics, where mistakes ripple widely.
- **Political risk.** She was a stranger outside her region, there was an outcry over her appointment, and she faced a steering committee she had to report to.

**Was she right to accept?** Yes, with the caveat that she had little real choice, since Steve insisted. But accepting was the right move:

- Steve chose her for her strength, which is rallying people, in a project likely to generate conflict.
- High-risk, high-visibility projects are how people reach VP level. Declining could have signalled a lack of ambition.
- It paid off: she was identified for succession planning, received stock options, and was invited to strategic meetings.

The risk was real, though. A failure would have damaged a strong reputation. She was also set up with weak support: Steve wouldn't intervene against Patty, and some colleagues undermined her by sending problem employees.

## 5. The incident with Indra at the steering committee

**Handled well overall.**

**What worked:**

- She admitted she hadn't answered and asked Indra to reformulate the question, rather than bluffing.
- Humor defused the tension. "I also have one [an accent]" matched Indra's tone and showed she wouldn't be intimidated.
- She confirmed that her second answer was satisfactory, which was assertive but not aggressive.
- She stayed calm in front of a feared VP.

**Risks:**

- A joke at the expense of a tough, powerful VP could have backfired.
- The fact that she hadn't answered suggests she may have been underprepared on the business market. She also left feeling uneasy, so the relationship wasn't yet secure.

**Outcome:** It paid off. Indra later became an ally, and the two developed strategies together. Showing composure and authenticity earned respect.

## 6. Was Carrie right to experiment with a new marketing strategy on her own initiative? What was the downside?

**Judgement: justified by the result, but risky in process.**

**In favor:**

- Marketing, led by Gerry, wasn't asserting itself and sales were behind schedule. Someone needed to act.
- She tested on a small scale (20 employees) and compared results, so the risk was contained and evidence-based.
- She was transparent, telling the committee at the next meeting. The results (a strong sales increase) spoke for themselves.
- Indra's response, "you've just set a new benchmark," showed that results-driven leaders valued the initiative.

**Potential downsides:**

- **Overstepping authority.** Gerry's note warned that she had no authority to change the strategy. It could have been seen as usurping Marketing's role or as insubordination.
- **Damaging relationships.** Gerry (a direct report) and Marketing might feel undermined, and she was still seen as an outsider to the rest of North America.
- **Political fallout.** A failed experiment, or even a success presented badly, could have cost her credibility and the support of the steering committee.
- **Better practice:** She could have asked for forgiveness *and* permission, informing the committee beforehand or consulting Gerry. Relying on results as justification works only when the result is good, so it's "ask forgiveness, not permission" with a lucky outcome.